Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

Marshall Allen

After fulfilling his military commitment, saxophonist Marshall Allen found an outlet for his creative impulses in an early version of the Sun Ra Arkestra in 1958. Mr. Allen took over the leadership of the ensemble after Sun Ra's passing, and continues to keep the band engaged and productive.

Marshall was interviewed via Zoom on July 19, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: What a pleasure to meet you, Maestro Marshall Allen.

MA: Uh huh.

MR: It's a pleasure to talk with you today. Can you hear me all right?

MA: Yeah, I hear you fine.

MR: Very good. And you're in a rather landmark house in Philadelphia, is that right?

MA: That's right. I'm trying to get it fixed up right now and everything's out of order.

MR: I see.

MA: You know.

MR: Well I wish I was there with you but I'm in Utica, New York and through the magic of technology at least we can talk this way.

MA: Oh yeah, it's good. Yeah.

MR: Well I've got an awful lot I'd like to talk about it in about an hour, but I'm interested in when you were a young man and you joined the military, the now famous 92nd Infantry — the Buffalo soldiers.

MA: Yeah that was my first assignment there, they was forming a 28-piece military band that they needed at Fort Huachuca at 92nd Division, Buffalo Division. And they needed a band. So I was in Fort Meade so I went to sign up for assignment to go, what I wanted to do, so I wanted to play music. So they said oh yeah we have a vacancy of 28 people, we've got to get 28 people to make up this Army band, the 92nd, the 370th Infantry Band.

MR: Go ahead, sir.

MA: They sent me to Fort Huachuca, me and about five people went to Fort Huachuca to join the band. They was making the band. They only had about five people there and they needed 28 pieces, to replace a military band you know.

MR: And then you found yourself in Paris eventually?

MA: Well yeah, but first I went to the 92nd Division, so when they had to go to the mountains in Italy they transferred the band to headquarters in Sam Houston, Texas, and they put, attached us to the 2nd Calvary Division in Fort Clark, Texas. And from there we went to

Mississippi and we stayed out there and then from Mississippi we went to Europe in a convoy, a 13-ship convoy. They went in 1945.

MR: Now the military was segregated for you, is that correct?

MA: Oh yeah, yeah, yeah. It was, you know, segregated the same way, which I was used to. I'm 97 so you know I'm used to dealing with segregation.

MR: Indeed. Well you've seen the country change a lot over the years, for sure. What is your memory of one of the most significant changes in society for you?

MA: I don't know, I just want to do what I want to do and go where I want to go and do and that's it. And you get used to it and then when you grow up with that stuff it's already in you so you have to have some discipline not to get off on things, you just do what you do and what you can do, and see if you can do anything else. It's simple.

MR: Okay. Did you ever consider doing anything else besides music?

MA: No, music was what I wanted, it was the only thing that keep me well being, the music was doing me good and I did everything for the music.

MR: You could have decided at the time, after World War II bop was starting to become, you know, the way to play I guess. And you were associated a little bit with James Moody. Were you looking for something else besides bebop?

MA: No, I was playing music, so I went to the conservatory and studied under Delacluse, the clarinetist and it was getting my technique up and classical music and everything. All music.

MR: I see.

MA: So I like all the music, because everything's good when you listen when somebody's playing it from the spirit and the heart you see.

MR: Yes.

MA: That's country music or blues, everything is from, you know real music. So I'm not prejudiced against the music, any kind.

MR: Well that attitude served you well trying to fit in with Sun Ra. Can you describe to me what it was that attracted you and compelled you to want to be part of that?

MA: I was working at Revere Camera Company with polishing lenses, filters for cameras you know. I was a polisher, I was polishing. And I used to go to, around the corner to a record store and buy records because I liked to hear all kinds of records. I'm from the old school when all the bands was swinging. So the guy told me, "I've got a real nice record for you. It's a thing with Sun Ra and Cecil Taylor and a whole lot of people is on it." But I heard this band playing this tune "Super Blonde" and something else, and I said oh man, that's a nice thing here. I was in that. And the guy says, "Hey man that's Sun Ra. He rehearses every night and he's always looking for talent." I said, "Oh yeah?" He said, "Where you live?" I said, "I live on the south side." He said, "Yeah, Sun Ra is on the south side, about

six blocks from where I live, rehearsing every night with the musicians." I said, "Yeah, okay." I took my horn when I got out of work that night to meet Sun Ra.

MR: When you got to the house did you hear music coming out of it?

MA: No it was Sun Ra used to have rehearsals, they had a lot of ballrooms in the old days you know, remember the ballrooms?

MR: Yes.

MA: You'd put your tie on and dress up, and dance. So he would have an empty ballroom that he would rehearse in, you know, one they didn't have no activity in. So that's the way he built the band. So I went up there and I said well it's in my neighborhood, about six blocks from where I lived. So I went up there with my horn and I've been there ever since. That was in 1958.

MR: Yeah I did the math. I think that's 63 years, Mr. Allen.

MA: That's right.

MR: You know we celebrate Freddie Green and Harry Carney for how long they stayed with Basie and Ellington, but you've got them beat by quite a bit.

MA: Yeah. Well you know I admired all of those although I was looking up to them, I wanted to play like Johnny Hodges.

MR: Yeah as a matter of fact, one of the well known critics described, "Here's Marshall Allen's playing as Johnny Hodges from another dimension."

MA: Yeah because I looked up to him because he had this big old big fat beautiful tone.

MR: Yes.

MA: Yeah so he played so beautifully. I said that's what I want to do.

MR: Was it difficult to fit into the band or at that point was it sort of like a big band and Sun Ra had parts for everyone?

MA: Sun Ra had parts for everything, and every day new parts. Every day he had something new. And he'd change what he's got and the song, he'd change the stuff every day. He was amazing how he could do that, write the music like you'd write a letter. And he had so much music that the musicians couldn't keep up there was so many things. So I said boy, and I didn't understand none of that stuff in one sense because I was all thinking I know. And when I got with Sun Ra he just broke — tore that stuff away, that ego was gone, that part of me. I just like I don't know nothing and I have to learn because he had a different way of attacking the notes like every band has a — you know Duke Ellington because of the way they sound and articulate notes and stuff. Well Sun Ra had his style, the way he would punctuate, and you speak, like speech you know.

MR: Yes.

MA: So you have to learn that and you have to learn the dimensions he's playing in and not — in the squares, like in the spiral, it's always moving. And he's talking about space and

something like that and everybody's wondering can you go to space and go to the moon. And along that time they put Sputnik up there, you see?

MR: Indeed. And now we have UFOs that seem to be circling around. I wonder what Sun Ra would have thought of that?

MA: Well when we was riding in Oklahoma on tour, and one of those UFOs was following us. And in Oklahoma you could see, you know, it was beautiful out there anyway. But it was following us and it followed us about five, ten minutes. And I was at the World's Fair in New York, the World's Fair they had there, and I've seen six of them. And I was looking up and I was walking with the baritone player, Pat Patrick. And we're standing there looking up at this and they was just making a show, and then they said [scats] and gone. So I've seen them about two or three times in my life. A UFO. I don't know, I guess they be a UFO, an unidentified thing.

MR: Very interesting. Did Sun Ra include things in his written music other than actual notes? Like —

MA: Yeah because you had to interpret it, you had to interpret what the music is. The music is a language. It's just like a language that you study. You have to know the language and all of the syllables and the nouns and pronouns, whatever. You see? And his music was that way. It was — he told me that there was a thousand ways to play a note, band the sound, there's a thousand ways to do it. So he had one of those ways — the way you attacked a note, and play it forward and back, instead of straight on, on, on. It's flowing like this. See there's forward, back. Forward, and it soothes the whole spirit and soul because it's — that swing.

MR: I'm so pleased you described it that way because I was envisioning if some of the musicians who were schooled like in the very precise big bands like Benny Goodman or — if they were to come in and play Sun Ra's music he probably wouldn't like it very precise.

MA: Well they knew when Sun Ra would teach them how to play and what to play and to play from the spirit, not from the head, you see? It's a difference. What you know and what you feel is two different — so he didn't want what you knew. Cancel that, which is what? And then you want to let the spirit, right, he lived life with the spirit of things telling you more than what you know.

MR: Do you try to continue with that philosophy with the current Arkestra members?

MA: Well everyone that came to Sun Ra came to Sun Ra. He didn't do much recruiting. You understand? They would come because they wanted to play in his band. So that's the way it is now. They come when they want — when somebody comes that means the Creator sent somebody to help us out, to do the part. Because they are sincere and they really want to do it. But I don't have to go out and hire people. You understand?

MR: I see.

MA: Because all I do is sit here and what I need will come, it will come along. And that said, being sincere and open minded and really want to do it. And it's not about money or fame or all of that stuff. It's about your well being and the well being for those who you play for. Music is a language.

MR: Yeah. Over the years I would assume that there was members in the group that really embraced Sun Ra's equations, and then some members who didn't so much.

MA: Well that's just like why it's a natural thing. That's the way America is. Some people believe in democracy and others believe something else. So all of those that believe in something that's better for being wins. You know?

MR: I see.

MA: Because that's the way it is. It's just like life is. You know?

MR: Okay. I think sometimes we try to make things too complicated. But I'm wondering how he dealt with such a — I mean I've been in my share of bands and eventually there's always personality conflicts, people grate on each other's nerves and so forth. Did he try to fix those things or did he just let them play out?

MA: He was what they call a natural, a natural. He was the kind of person that he could look at you and look at your potentials and your faults and everything. He could read you like a book. And you couldn't get away with anything, with the slick stuff. He would expose you, you know? So he's saying that's what you know and you're going in that direction and I'm not going in that direction, I'm going in the direction of what you feel and the spirit of things, which is real. So if you — most people come in with "I know this, I know that." I knew how to play but I didn't know how to take that playing I'm doing and make it real, the spirit you know? So when he said I don't want to hear what you know, I want to hear what you don't know. Or I want you to do what you're not doing.

MR: And did that result in some of the techniques that you now use on the alto?

MA: Yeah, because I had to try everything I could think of, good, bad or what I think is good, what I think — you know, but until I could get the spirit, the soul of playing something, you see? So for example, a professional drummer was in and Sun Ra was playing a tune. So he wanted, he told the drummer, so the drummer would know he knew there was a wealth of professional drummers. He was playing I mean playing everything he knew. So Sun Ra said no, you don't understand what I mean. So they went outside and there were some children out there. So he said, "Come here little boy," and little boy come in. And he said, "Now here's some sticks, this is the drum, now play — when I play you play with me." So the little boy didn't know anything and he did perfect. Perfect drum so, drum with Sun Ra playing his music. So he told the professional, "You see what I mean? He doesn't know anything and he's going to do by feeling and spirit." And he did the

right thing, that's the way the spirit works. You see? It's showing that because you know that's not relevant. You know?

MR: Would Sun Ra vocalize things like no don't make it sound like that, make it sound like this, and then would he sing at you?

MA: He'd have you either sing it, play it and memorize it, and then change it. After you remember your parts he'd give you another one.

MR: I can picture myself and trying to deal with that and I'd like have a little, some score paper and I'd be trying to write it down.

MA: Yes that's what we were doing on the side of the music we'd put the little changes on the side and we'd look at the music — it was little dots and dashes so that we could remember how to phrase something.

MR: Yeah, and then the next day it's something different.

MA: And then that's gone. You'd get something new. If you'd come to rehearsal today and you got your part and you played it perfect, good or whatever. You come tomorrow and you didn't come near, then when you come the next day the music changed. Your part don't fit no more. You have to get your new part, if you miss a rehearsal. So in other words every time there was a rehearsal you'd have to be there.

MR: And eventually there's a performance or a concert and there, maybe by Sun Ra's design this music is going to be changed that day also?

MA: Right. Because he got somebody else added in. Every person added in the music changed. So he'd either get some musicians and add them in, and it would change. So then what you did with the other musicians don't fit with these. You see? And that's frustrating because we all, when you learn your parts you walk in and sit down in your chair and you're ready to roll. And you get there and the song don't go that way no more. Because you wasn't at rehearsal yesterday to get the change. And then the change is added then you're lost. You're trying to play it the old way and the leader changed the expression.

MR: Did Sun Ra have a temper? Would he get angry?

MA: Yeah, yeah. If you mess with his music, butchering his music, if he got a pencil or something in his hand he'd throw it at you. All the kind of temperamental masters do that. They've got a way of getting you — telling you that you're not doing, the stuff you ain't doing right, they get frustrated.

MR: When that house in Philadelphia was sort of communal and you had a group of people living there, what kind of things, the day to day, you know cooking and taking care of the house, how did that stuff happen? Were you assigned tasks?

MA: Yeah. Everybody had something to do. He had enough people, all walks, some that would do plumbing, the carpentry, artists. He had all kinds of people in the band that did

that. And if they wanted to do anything we'd have to do it ourself. And that was the thing. You come here, you have to take care of your business, you have to learn and you have to have some discipline, and we'd do what we need to do ourself. If a window's broken you have to go do your part and fix the window. If the door was broken or you need some carpentry work or some ceiling work you'd do it. So it was like a self storage you know, that anything you want done — so he wanted a sink I think, in the room, so that one of the drummers were plumbers, so you'd call for a plumbing issue. And then they wanted the doors and what's-the-name sidewalks fixed, we had a carpenter. They'd know how to do that. So in other words if you wanted something painted we had a painter right in the band, they wouldn't have to hire any company for any kind of work. It was the same way dealing with the music you see?

MR: Did it change the dynamic of the band when June Tyson became part of the group? And do you think it was difficult for her being the only woman in the group?

MA: No because she was the kind of woman that could be with me and it wasn't about those sexy things and all that B.S. you know. It was nothing. Because she carried herself in that manner that you know she was more like in the family, like a sister you know. And that's the way she carried herself. So she was the only woman in the band with all these men, you know, but everybody had mutual respect for her.

MR: I see. Did you ever hear people complain or question Sun Ra's decisions when he wasn't around?

MA: Yeah. I know there was a night in Chicago, the trumpet player was an accomplished musician, a professional. He wrote music. And he got mad at Sun Ra because Sun Ra was playing his space stuff and all these different systems. And he said, "Oh you can't do that stuff." And he'd go — and they were arguing on this stuff and Sun Ra said, "What are you talking about?" And he got mad at Sun Ra and just slapped Sun Ra. Sun Ra turned the other cheek. So he was used to it, being in the square, in a precise — then he could go out of there, it's not right, you see?

MR: I see.

MA: So that's the way Sun Ra's music was, they had these ones that had the square mind, just like me. I had that square mind. I could read that stuff and I thought I knew everything. 'Cause I was a nobody. And then when it comes to the spirit it was a whole different — everything I played is nice but, "It's not what I want."

MR: Wow. Was there any anticipation of like a weekly payday?

MA: Payday? If you're with Sun Ra you're the last one to get paid. Everybody else get their regular dues and so you live in the house and you're with Sun Ra, you know, so don't be putting your hand out. That was one thing that used to upset me because I would need some money but I'd be part of that, you always wait, he has to pay each fella.

MR: Oh that's so interesting. I mean how could you have personal relationships? If you wanted to take someone out on a date, you know, and you didn't have any bread?

MA: If the date didn't have none you might as well stay home. Because that's the way it was. Any time you get a date he'd give you some work to do. And then you would probably be late for the date or don't even make it. If he'd see you going out the door he'd go "Wait a minute, do this before you go." And that "do this before you go" and two hours later you're still there doing that before you go. And by that time it's too late.

MR: Did the man ever sleep?

MA: No, he'd catnap, he didn't sleep.

MR: I see.

MA: Like he'd sit in a chair, "Play the song" and he'd do that [nods off]. And you'd finish the song and then you'd have "Play that from Letter B down again." I don't know why that. Again. And while we're playing he'd say "Uh, uh, uh" then he'd give you another number. Same way he'd do on the stage. He'd give an 8-bar introduction. And if you ain't got your music, you'd be down trying to find, where is the song, he changes the song. So by the time you find, you look under your chair where your music, you find your music and you're ready to play, he done changed the song to another song. And then you say oh what's up man, and you'd go back down and look for it.

MR: Why did he do that?

MA: Because he wanted you to have some discipline, learn songs by memory or whatever, and when he changed it or he hit it, he hit that chord he'd expect you to come in. Sometimes he gives you four bars, sometimes he gives you eight bars. If you ain't in, the number changed.

MR: How did you know, I mean at different times in the band you had four, five saxophone players and a few brass. How did you know when it was your turn to solo?

MA: That's what I get [nods]. See? Or a look. Just a look. That's it. And he'd be playing and he'd look over at you like that man. If you don't come in, oh boy.

MR: How about going out? Did you have to try to sense, okay I've played long enough here or were you keeping one eye on him because he might nod?

MA: I'm keeping my eye on him too while I'm playing. Oh yeah. So I'm playing, and I'm just playing and just know when to stop. Know when I stop. That's why they don't know anything and the spirit says, "that's it" you know. You automatically know when to stop.

MR: When the band went to Egypt in 1971 I think, and — how did those audiences react to the band and the fact that you had a look, Egyptian-looking costuming, and here you are in Egypt. Can you recall what that was like?

MA: Yeah they liked that. They liked the music, they liked — they respect Sun Ra and they called him Sun Ra, and Sun Ra was talking by name to Egyptians and all those things.

And the music is the same way, they would come to listen to the music because Sun Ra had that spirit that they'd know he wasn't a phony. You see?

MR: Did you ever have the opposite experience, like there's a famous incident where the premiere of "The Rite of Spring" by Stravinsky and there was almost a riot in the auditorium in the theater. I wonder if you ever played a gig where people were expecting something else?

MA: Yeah, in the Black Forest it was the same way. We played in Germany in the Black Forest and played classical, Sun Ra would play the classics, and then we was in Vienna so he played their [hums]. But he put it [scats]. So he gave me that solo. So I had to play that while they played the background. And he'd take classical and use it and play. Yeah. Russia and all, we'd play. He could play the classics, so he was a well-rounded musician.

MR: I see.

MA: You see? Yeah.

MR: The term Afro-Futurism has been written about a lot, and Sun Ra is always included in it. Was it a term that you were familiar with at the time? And did you think that Sun Ra had the intent to be part of Afro-Futurism?

MA: Well with his music everything's in. It's for the world. It's for the whole universe you see? And that's why he got different names for his Arkestra. The Space Arkestra, the Jet Set Arkestra, Omniverse, they've got all different names and you've got all the different music that goes with it. Each thing he'd say. So the Jet Set he would put on the Jet Set things and play the Jet Set. And then the Omniverse, and then everything. The Outer Space Arkestra. And it was like a show band where the musician was just sitting there playing music, they were part of it. And the colors, the right colors on you make you stand out — all this for the show. And everything — he'd take out, he'd say, "Oh no, you don't look right in that" and he'd give you something else to make you stand out. Your personality and all. And the uniforms.

MR: Did humor play any part in the concerts? Were there things that Sun Ra intended to be humorous and the audience maybe was not sure?

MA: No. It's in the music. If you listen to it and you're paying attention and you knew those things. Then he leaves space for you to put a part in the composition. That's when you get a little solo, you see? You get a solo in his composition. He'd point to you and you'd play it. So you have to add to the composition. If there's no composition at all then you've got to pay attention to what he's doing and put your part in there. So just like I'm talking to you, I say, "We're going to play a song." You don't know what it is, you never heard it? I'm going to start and then you've got to put your part on. That's when you create music you know?

MR: You just made me get a flash of John Coltrane [scats] and the "Ascension" record? Yeah. And there was no composition except like a lick, and then everybody was like joined in. Were you aware of when that record came out or the late —

MA: Yeah I remember that. Because he used to come and talk with Sun Ra you know. He would come up to where we lived and have a conversation with Coltrane.

MR: And was John Gilmore in on those?

MA: Yeah John Gilmore was there all the time. Yeah.

MR: Were you a Coltrane —

MA: Yeah I liked it. There's no people I don't like in music. Because everybody has something. And if you have a music mind and you know that there's all dimensions in music. It's only different people playing. Like if it's a rock tune you could find something in that. If it's a — any kind you see? So you find beauty and a sense of well being in all of music. So I'm not prejudiced against the music. When it's classical it's still good. You could hear them doing a wonderful job in the hall.

MR: Did you ever go to the, in Philadelphia, the Third Street Record Store?

MA: Yeah we used to have our records — I had a big poster down there. Yeah, we used to sell records there.

MR: Well the owner, amongst other people I've spoken to said, "Well a Sun Ra concert changed my life." It had that —

MA: It did a lot of things to different people, it did something for different people. It changed mine too. You see?

MR: I would say so. May I ask what your grandchildren think of your profession?

MA: Well what a bunch of kids think, why are you doing it. And now they see that I'm doing it and they like it.

MR: I'm glad.

MA: When I was doing it I wasn't making much money and stuff so everybody was — oh why don't you do this to make some money. It wasn't about money, it was about preparing the goods and then you sell it. Then you will spend your time making a product of work, then it will sell itself. You see what I mean? But if you're worrying about material money and all of this, and you put out a bad product it don't last. What we put out is from the heart and from hard sweat, and no other values, not that, until we finished a product and you put it out there and it goes. It sells itself.

MR: And then you're on to the next one.

MA: Right.

MR: Yeah. Did you ever witness Sun Ra, I'm not sure how to ask this, do anything that seemed inexplicable or miraculous?

MA: Well if you look at it he's supposed to do a certain thing in your eye. But he was a natural. So if you did something you understood if he done something that's different. Do you understand that? In other words, it's like the politicians, the same way. They've got a thing and then you've got one. But Sun Ra would mix with all of that. If you're the guy that's doing all the crazy stuff, he also knows about that you see. So it wasn't like he was sitting on a pedestal and that's it. He was down there with you. So everything you do he knows about it. So if you do something wrong he knows about that too. You see?

MR: What if you snuck out to —

MA: He know about that.

MR: To play a funk gig and make a few bucks, he would know about that?

MA: Well you could go play with somebody but he never — as long as it don't get in his schedule.

MR: Okay.

MA: Yeah, with his teaching. You could go play with other people, we all did that you know. But when he had his then he'd play that. But he never said a thing about not playing with somebody else. We used to play with somebody else. I played with Olatunji for four years in the band too you know. Yeah we was playing that high life music and stuff.

MR: This may be a very obvious question but what was the mood of the band when Sun Ra passed?

MA: Well everybody was wondering what am I supposed to do now? Supposed to go home just like he said to do. He said don't worry, carry on. So that's what I did. I was worrying about now what am I going to do with all this stuff, all this music, what — do I walk away from it or do I stand my ground and work hard and keep it up? So I had to make that decision. So I made a decision, nobody else left, what am I going to do all these years wasted? No. Carry on as best you can.

MR: Did you have to deal with let's say other interested parties in Sun Ra's estate and legacy?

MA: Well that — part of it went one way, this part went, this here went this way. So all you could do is put it together. And that's the way it is. Sun Ra wanted me to keep the band so I'll keep the band and keep the music longer, and found whatever they get that goes that way. You see what I mean?

MR: What is the state of the music library? You still have a great deal of that printed, actual hand written music?

MA: Yeah. I had all of it, all the music was left here and I had so much music it's overwhelming.

MR: Yes I can imagine. And the music, the parts he had written for some certain size group which of course now have changed, and if you pull out —

MA: Well if I can remember, I mean in the early days when he left I could remember all — I tried to put this puzzle together you see, because it was fresh on my mind but now it's been what, twenty, thirty years? You know the parts kind of get away so I'll go in another direction for what I feel.

MR: You mean you'll adapt the piece for your own interpretation and what you have now?

MA: Yeah. Well I've got to do it, because I can't remember all the jigsaw puzzles and all the different parts of Sun Ra because he was always changing stuff. So that left it open to me, whatever — I'm used to it being changed, so I change it.

MR: Besides the Fletcher Henderson music, did he put key signatures in the music?

MA: Yeah. He wrote music like he would write a letter.

MR: And did he —

MA: He'd dot all the I's and cross all your T's.

MR: I'm glad you put it that way.

MA: Yeah so he'd put the signature and the key. That solved that. There's nothing wrong with the music but if he gave it to you so fast you've got to jot down your way of remembering things. He makes a perfect piece of music. You still have so much other stuff in it that you have to jot down your little riffs and your little what time you come in you know. Because it's hard to remember all that. And then get on the gig and don't even play the song.

MR: Did you ever have a trumpet player behind you go, "Hey Marshall, how's my part go?"

MA: Yeah. I did all of that. Where am I? Don't forget.

MR: Did he write a score first?

MA: No I don't do anything the normal way you see? Man I can give you your part now you see? That's your part now to start but that is not the whole composition. So it's not, it's everything that I thought musicians were supposed to do and the way you do it, it's all the opposite you see. And I used to have everything written out real nice and beautiful and oh, I got the sheet, and then he'd change all of that stuff. And then when I'd look at the music again you had to understand wait a minute, that's been changed. You see? So it was like if you don't put yourself in the spirit you can't function. But when you do that man, all the other insignificant things are put aside, then you remember and it will come up at the right time, right place. You see?

MR: Well you have a lot of faith.

MA: I do.

MR: That things are going to work out, and if they don't then that creates something that works out in a different way I guess.

MA: It's just like the way you think today, what about tomorrow. You see? Tomorrow you've got some other thoughts. So it's vibrations every day. Now today you do this and

tomorrow you read about what you done yesterday but you don't do the same thing. You see natural — so there's nothing except to capture that and use it and put it in the right place. And that's like life is. You put the right things in the right place things go better for you or the like.

MR: If a Caucasian musician was attracted to Sun Ra's music and showed up like you did at a rehearsal, would he have been invited, or she, to, like into the band?

MA: Yeah. I had the United Nations band in the band. People from — Arabs and Englishmen and Africans, everybody on the planet has been through this band. I mean all the races in the planet.

MR: I'm pleased to hear that. Was there a reason that — was there more women in the band over the years?

MA: Well we had dancers.

MR: Oh right.

MA: They were dancers. And we had quite a few dancers. We'd use a certain amount each time. We had dancers from all over the States.

MR: I wanted to tell you that I watched a wonderful video this morning of a rather symphonic piece that started out with a harp and there was a big hole in the stage. And I was afraid you were going to fall in it.

MA: I'm glad you found it.

MR: You remember that set up? There was a hole in the stage on purpose it looked like and I was wondering is someone going to come out of that, but I kept thinking Marshall, please don't fall in that thing.

MA: We had the singer, the singer was in Japan singing, and he walked to the edge of the stage and disappeared. And what he had done, it was about five or ten feet, he fell down in the audience. And I turned around like this, I said, "Where'd the singer go?" And he was down in the audience and the people were gathering all around and the band kept playing. He disappeared and fell down off the stage, down on top of the people.

MR: Well with all the performing that the band has done I'm sure there's been some what we would call train wrecks you know, like no equipment, people getting lost, and —

MA: Yeah, and then all the music got stuck on the train and we didn't have no music now we have to play the gig without the music. So we played it. So it was a different gig because we had to play by memory everything. Ain't but so much you can remember on Sun Ra's tunes. You might remember the first introductions and the basic number but all the rest of the stuff in between you don't know who or what, what, what, what. So we'd have to go on anyway. So we played all evening without one piece of music because the music got hung up on the train or something. You know it was late coming.

MR: Was the role of the bass player different from an average band like Count Basie? You know like if that had happened to Count Basie group I would think many of the musicians would be keying in to where is the bass player going. That will help me to remember my part?

MA: Yeah. You listen to the bass, yeah of course. Because each part — but when he changed you've got to change too. You see? So you're listening to that and it's not just one thing.

MR: Did you guys kind of take it in stride when he instructed you to start singing?

MA: Well now you're a musician, you're supposed to be able to carry a tune and you're playing one, and you'll be able to not sit there like a musician all straight up and stiff and playing correct, because life ain't like that no way. So that's why he left some space in there where you could be what it is. You write a form, and the space in between you put it in. See?

MR: I hear that you just finished —

MA: So then you have to dance, sing, and be a clown and everything else. You've got to be a natural person who does things in your life. You know. So that's why I say most of the musicians would sit down and play their horn and wipe their mouth and sit there like that. But no, that's not entertaining. You put on some colors, people are looking and feel it, and when you're playing they see all these nice clothes and the [inaudible] people. And you're not just sitting there like a statue. You're dancing like they would dance, you're singing, you're doing all these things. So that's what he wanted the musicians to do besides playing the music.

MR: The things that I've seen, the pictures, the video and the photographs, it seemed to me, and I very well could be wrong, but that Sun Ra usually had the same expression on his face.

MA: Well his expressions were — his expressions, they were like the same expression on my face. I laugh [gestures] it's nothing.

MR: Okay.

MA: You know I mean but you know if he gets into a certain look then you say uh oh, what did I do.

MR: Then you see an expression, huh?

MA: Yeah. But when you do something you'd get that look then you go uh oh, what have I done now, you see?

MR: How would he fire somebody in the band?

MA: Huh?

MR: How would he have fired someone in the band?

MA: He doesn't fire anybody really. He'd put them in the discipline box you know. And they go up under his discipline. So that means if you walk out the door he'd go, "Wait a

minute, before you go, do this for me, do that. I can't find this." And it might be right up under him, but he'd have you looking all night for it. Because he's got so many discipline ways. Make you work, make you write music, make you do a lot of things and see what you're gonna do.

MR: I understand you just finished another recording?

MA: Yeah, two. [to off camera] How many recordings did we do? Two?

MR: Does a Sun Ra recording session go fairly quickly compared to a lot of bands?

MA: Oh boy we got so many stuff. He'd be anywhere and record. Like we'd be at rehearsal and he'd be recording. So you'd get it right, it would come out one way and we'd go in the studio it would come out another way. Same song. You see? So he'd be recording everything. That's why so many tapes and music because every day, seven days a week. Now you put a year on that and seven days a week is a lot of recordings. And you've got stacks and stacks of tapes. I've got garbage bags full of tapes. Man you know those big industrial bags? Full of tapes.

MR: Wow. Well this has been —

MA: Every day. Every day.

MR: This has been really fascinating for me talking to you, and I want to thank you for your time and I want to read a quote to sort of wrap up. And you were writing about the time that you were getting to know Sun Ra and you wanted to get going and he kept talking about the Bible and Egyptian mythology and then he said, "We're going to play this music for the twenty-first century." And you said, "I've got to wait that long?"

MA: Yeah. With no pay or half pay. No you mean I had to wait until the twenty-first century to make some money?

MR: Well now you're in the twenty-first century, you've been doing it for —

MA: Still haven't made no money. So I'm glad that the music, I've got the music, I put that out there.

MR: All right.

MA: I did something good. But the money ain't come yet. Still waiting on it.

MR: Where do you think Sun Ra's spirit is now?

MA: Well I know it's around here. It has to be, because he had told us not to Harlem, Queens, [inaudible] over the thing, you keep moving. You know? You take the stuff he done that's of worth and it's for the people, and put that out there and you teach that and you carry on. You see?

MR: Yeah. Well on that —

MA: He did so many things that no one person can keep up with all of it. He was an unusual person. Never could find anybody like him in my life. And I just devoted my life to him you know, to his work.

MR: And we're glad you did, sir.

MA: Well I am too.

MR: All right.

MA: Or else I'd be lost.

MR: All right.

MA: Going in another direction. Going on the right road going in the wrong direction.

MR: Thank you, sir.

MA: It's worth it for me. It kept me with some discipline and some responsibility and all the things that I've been ducking all my life. Being responsible.

MR: All right. Thank you very much.

MA: You're welcome.